

dreaded C-word. Modern medicine has conquered many diseases and halted others, but cancer has proved to be too smart, too complex, too hostile and too quick at outsmarting therapies. It has doubled its grip over the world in the last 20 years and struck deep roots in India—from 0.8 million in 2001 to 2.5 million people diagnosed now, says the World Health Organization. But there's a sunny side to this grim storyline: an explosion of new research, treatments, therapeutics and drugs that is changing the way cancer is perceived, understood and treated. "In cancer, some problems can be solved, some can't be and some can't be solved yet. But hope for

cancers has gone up from 50 per cent in 1975 to 66 per cent now, reports the American Cancer Society.

Topping the list are prostate (up from 69 to 100 per cent), breast (75 to 89), bladder (73 to 82), kidney (49 to 69), larynx (51 to 66) and so on. Childhood leukaemia, a disease that killed 75 per cent of the children it struck in the '70s, is now one where 73 per cent survive. With uterine cervical cancer, radiation therapy has achieved long-term cure rates of 85-90 per cent. Some of the same percentages now prevail in India since most of the treatments in the US are now available in the country. The glass, however, remains stub-



CANCER SURVIVOR RAJNI B. ARORA AT THE INDIAN CANCER SOCIETY WALK HELD IN DELHI

a cure is definitely on the cards," sums up Dr G.K. Rath, chief of the Rotary Cancer Hospital at All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), Delhi.

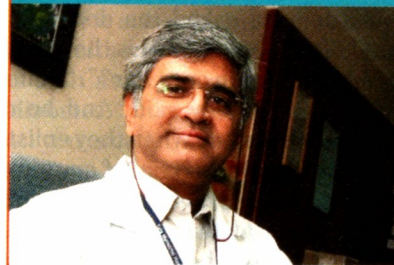
The idea of "cure" calls for a definition. "A majority of cancers recur in the first two-three years of diagnosis and hence a five-year survival has traditionally been equated with cure," says Dr R.A. Badwe, director of Tata Memorial Hospital & Cancer Research Institute (TMC), Mumbai. Going by that, globally two-thirds of patients survive at least five years after diagnosis now, compared to just half of patients 40 years ago (*J Clin Oncol*, 2009). Since 1990, cancer mortality rates have declined by 15 per cent. The survival rate for all can-

cerly half-empty as some cancers still defy treatment: lung to pancreas, liver to oesophagus.

It was a day like any other day. But try as he might, 40-year-old Ram Prakash (name changed) just couldn't get his arms through his shirt sleeves. Two days later, as he rammed his car into a tree for no apparent reason, he knew he was up against a major crisis. As a scientist cracking the IT-ivy league echelons, he had faced his share of challenges. But this was an equation no algorithm or meta math could solve. A fast-growing glioblastoma multiforme grade four tumour was spreading tentacles in his brain. As he entered the traumatic world of cancer, surgeries, chemotherapy and

DR R.A. BADWE

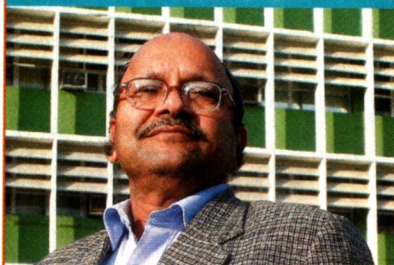
DIRECTOR, TATA MEMORIAL HOSPITAL & CANCER RESEARCH INSTITUTE, MUMBAI



"Targeted therapy is the buzzword in the treatment of cancers, whether it is myeloid leukaemia, breast, colon or lung cancer."

DR G.K. RATH

CHIEF, DR.B.R.A.I. ROTARY CANCER HOSPITAL, AIIMS, DELHI



"In cancer, some problems can be solved, some can't be solved yet. But hope for a cure is on the cards."

DR H. CHATURVEDI

CHIEF CONSULTANT & DIRECTOR, SURGICAL ONCOLOGY, MAX HEALTHCARE, DELHI



"A patient's quality of life, a much-ignored issue in our country, has improved dramatically as a result of the new innovations in cancer therapy."